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The EU-Canada FTA: An Econometric Assessment of The Impact on Goods Trade

Lars Nilsson+ and Alessandra Tucci

European Commission, Directorate-General for Trade and Economic Security, Brussels, Belgium

Abstract This paper econometrically assesses the impact on EU goods trade of the EU-Canada Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), which has been provisionally applied since 2017. As opposed to many other studies, this analysis is carried out at the most disaggregated level of publicly available trade data - the 8-digit level. Furthermore, we control for nomenclature changes and revisions. Most EU trade with Canada are concentrated in a handful of broad product groups which were already duty-free (MFN0 duties). The paper nevertheless finds positive and significant impacts on EU exports to Canada. On the other hand, CETA seems to have increased EU imports from Canada only in goods that were already subject to MFN0 duties. The results suggest that there are positive effects on trade of the agreement beyond tariff reductions, something which requires additional research.

Keywords: EU, Canada, CETA, FTA

JEL Classifications: F13, F14, F15

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I. Introduction

The purpose of this paper is to econometrically assess the trade impact of the EU-Canada Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), which provisionally entered into force in September 2017. The agreement aims to dismantle trade barriers and deepen economic integration between the two partners through reductions in tariffs, larger quotas as well as through regulatory cooperation.

The agreement is relatively recent and most work on CETA has been carried out by political scientists and legal scholars focusing on the negotiating- and ratification process and on specific topics/sectoral impacts.[1)] The number of econometric analyses of the trade and economic impact of CETA are few.[2)]

+Corresponding Author: Lars Nilsson
Senior Expert, European Commission, Directorate-General for Trade and Economic Security, Rue de la Loi 170, B 1040 Brussels. E-mail: lars.nilsson@ec.europa.eu
Co-Author: Alessandra Tucci
Economist, European Commission, Directorate-General for Trade and Economic Security, Rue de la Loi 170, B 1040 Brussels. E-mail: alessandra.tucci@ec.europa.eu
Note: The views expressed are the authors' own and do not necessarily reflect the views of the European Commission.

Anderson et al (2016) estimate the elasticity of trade to FTAs on past Canadian agreements. Using the latter for general equilibrium simulations, they find that Canada's exports and imports will increase by 14.7% and 15.2%, respectively due to CETA. They further note that the EU will benefit as well but that the effects on Canada will be larger.

Kutlina-Dimitrova (2023) describes a set of economic indicators before and after CETA provisional application. Her work shows, *inter alia*, that there has been an expansion of bilateral goods and services trade. This analysis does not attempt to establish any causal effect of CETA.

Ficarra and Millemaci (2024) analyse the effects of CETA on agricultural trade for the years 2012-2020 using PPML regressions on data aggregated from HS6 level to (the agricultural) chapter level of the Harmonised System (HS). They find that agricultural trade between the EU and Canada has increased by about 130% because of CETA.

In this paper, we focus our analysis on the EU. That is, we compare the goods trade impact of CETA to EU trade (exports and imports) with all other EU trading partners, while we leave Canadian trade with third countries out of the analysis. As opposed to many other studies, this analysis is carried out at the most disaggregated level of publicly available trade data - the 8-digit level.

II. EU Goods Trade with Canada and the World

In 2023, bilateral goods trade between the EU and Canada totalled some €77 billion of which €49 billion were EU exports to Canada and about €28 billion were EU imports.[3] According to the data for 2023, the EU is Canada's third largest trading partner, while Canada is the EU's fourteenth largest trading partner.

Overall, CETA removes duties for 98.6% of all Canadian tariff lines and for 98.7% of EU tariff lines. In specific cases, such as the automotive industry, tariffs are liberalized over a period of seven years. Both sides have agreed to eliminate almost all agricultural tariffs, except for some sensitive products such as beef and pork, for which an increase in quotas was agreed between the parties.[4]

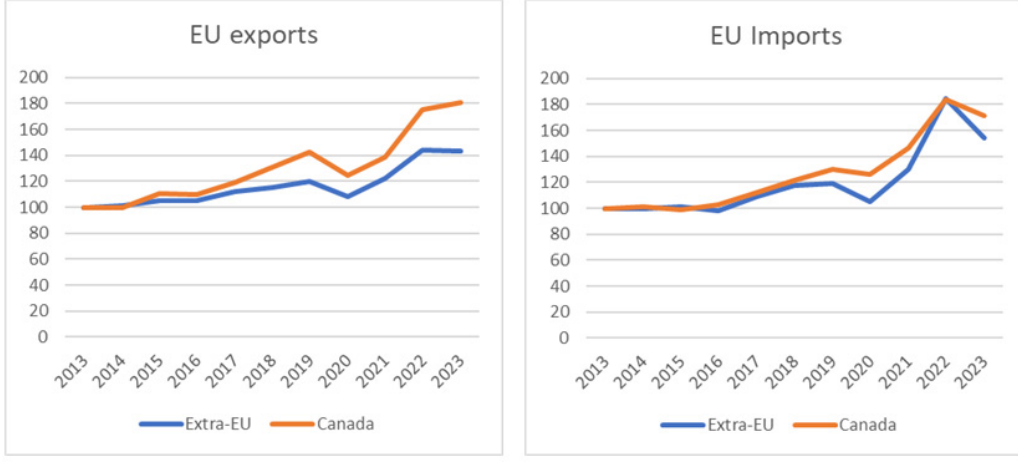
On non-tariff barrier (NTB) reductions, that may significantly impact goods trade, there is a dedicated protocol under CETA that enhances the mutual recognition of conformity assessments between the parties, thereby reducing the cost of complying with technical regulations and

1) See e.g., Paquin, S. (2021), Hurrelmann and Wendler (2023), Quirjo et al (2023) and Viju-Miljusevic, Weinar (2024).
2) We ignore the results of studies employing other types of methodologies such as computable general equilibrium modelling, see e.g., Hinz et al (2022) and Trade Impact (2024) for such ex-post analyses of the impact of CETA.
3) Source Eurostat (Comext).
4) European Commission (2017).

standards which apply to a wide range of products. Additionally, CETA allows EU companies to bid for public contracts in Canada at sub-federal levels of government, including provincial authorities.[5] The agreement also provides protection in the Canadian market for numerous EU agricultural products with specific geographical origins (protection of Geographical Indication). These measures are expected to lead to increased EU exports, but the extent to which they reduce trade costs is difficult to assess and such information is not available.

Figure 1 shows the evolution of EU exports to- and imports from Canada and the World over the 2013-2023 period (2013=100). Following a dip in 2020, both EU exports to and imports from Canada have increased rapidly, though much of the increases have taken place between 2021 and 2022. Some of this is due to the increase in inflation since 2021 and in energy prices in 2022, which have then slowed in 2023. EU trade with the world has also increased over the period. But it appears as if EU exports to Canada have increased more rapidly than EU exports to the rest of the world. EU imports from Canada decreased less than EU imports from the rest of the world from 2019 to 2020, while afterwards EU imports from Canada increased less than EU imports from the rest of the world.

Figure 1. EU exports and imports to and from Canada and the World, 2013-2023 (index=100 in 2013)

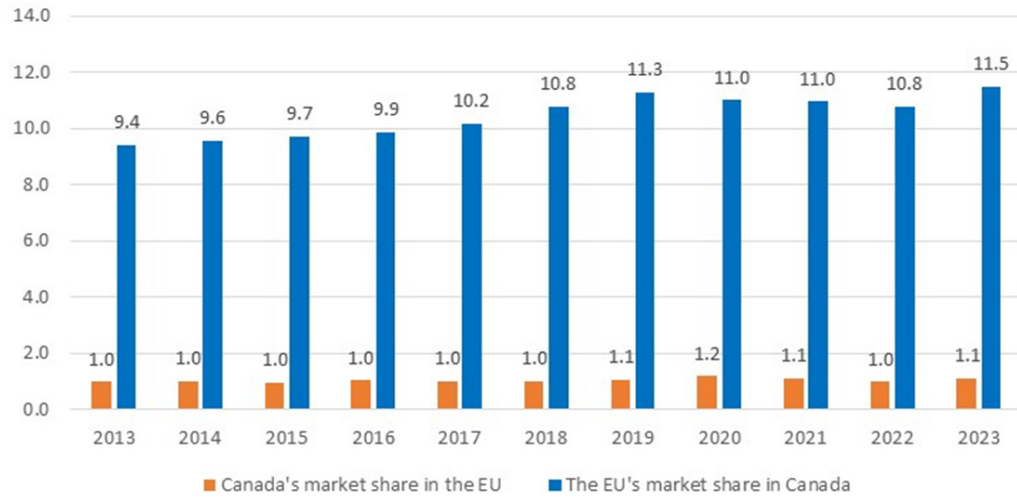


(Source) Eurostat (COMEXT).

The increase in trade between EU and Canada is reflected in the evolution of market shares (in goods) as shown in Figure 2. On average, the EU market share in Canada since 2018, that is after the entry into force of the agreement, is 13% higher than in the preceding five years (2013-2017). The corresponding increase in Canada's market share in the EU is about 8% (an increase from an average 1.01% in the 2013-2017 period compared to 1.08% in the 2018-2023 period).

5) Access to procurement markets at federal level is provided through the WTO's Government Procurement Agreement.

Figure 2. Market shares, 2013-2023 (%)



(Source) IMF (DoTS).

A. EU trade with Canada by product group

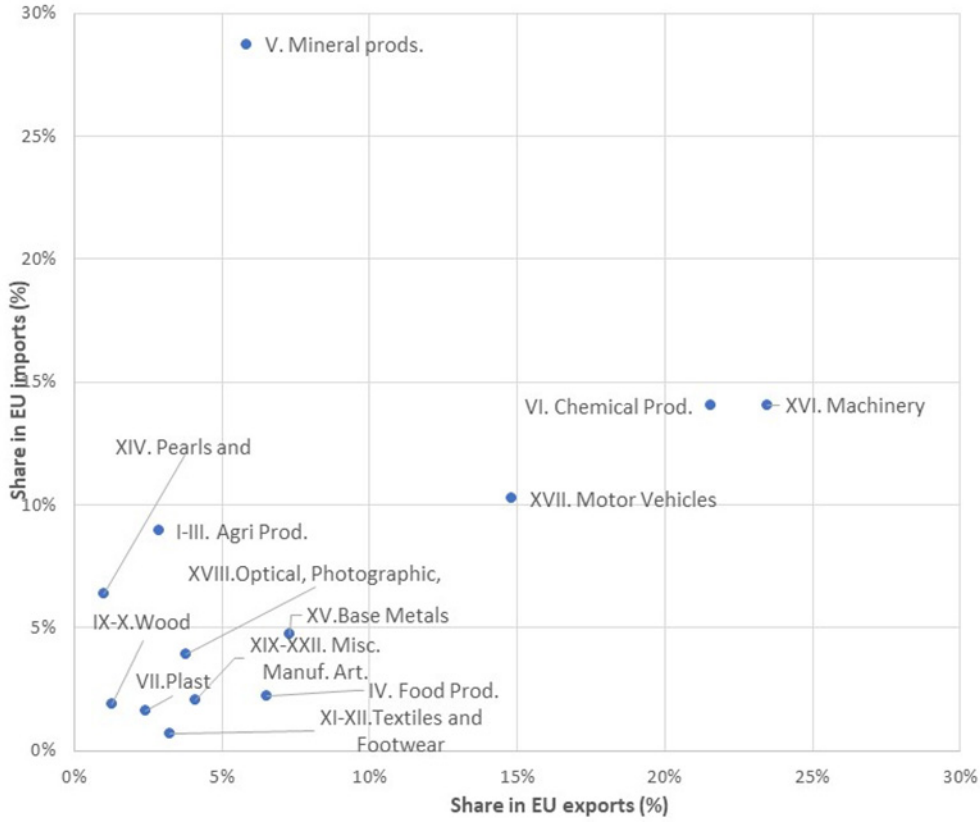
Figure 3 shows the share of EU *exports* and imports by HS section[6]. EU exports to Canada are concentrated in few a HS sections.[7] Three of those - Machinery (Section XVI), Chemicals (Section VI) and Transportation equipment, including motor vehicles (Section XVII) - represent almost 60% of EU exports to Canada with €11.5 billion (23%), €10.5 billion (22%) and €7 billion (15%) respectively. These categories are followed by Prepared foodstuffs (Section IV), Mineral products (Section V) and Base metals (Section XV), all at around €3 billion (about 6%). Agricultural products, except Prepared foodstuffs (Sections I to III) with €1.4 billion represent 3% of exports, similar to Textiles and footwear (sections XI and XII).

From the figure it is also clear that EU *imports* from Canada are concentrated in a handful of sections of the HS although these are not all the same as EU exports. Mineral products (Section V) dominate EU imports, accounting for almost 30%, or €7.9 billion. It is followed by Chemical products and Machinery which each represent 14% or €3.9 billion. If we add Transportation equipment, including motor vehicles and Pearls and semi-precious stones (Section XIV) representing 6% and 10% or €2.8 billion and €1.8 billion of EU imports respectively, these five sections of the HS together account for close to 75% of EU imports from Canada in 2023. Agricultural products, excluding Prepared foodstuffs with €2.5 billion represent 9% of EU imports from Canada.

6) Excluding the sections for which the sum of imports and exports is below €1 billion (or less than 1%). Namely Section VIII. Leather (Raw hides and skins, and saddlery) and Section XIII. Articles of stone, glass and ceramics.

7) See online Annex Table A1 for the correspondence between HS sections and HS chapters.

Figure 3. Distribution of EU trade with Canada by HS Section, 2023 (%)



(Source) Eurostat (COMEXT).

B. EU trade with Canada by tariff regime

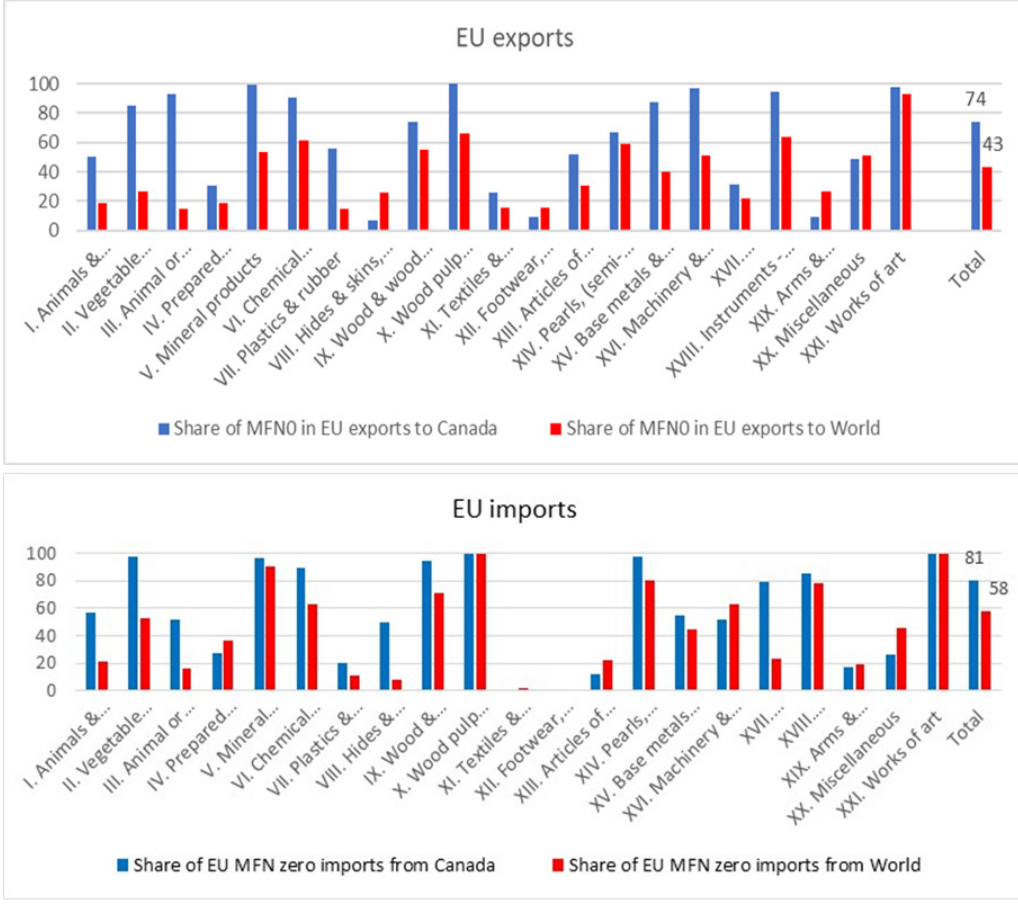
Figure 4 shows that trade between EU and Canada mostly takes place at Most Favoured Nation duties at 0% (MFN0): 74% of exports and 81% of imports. These shares are higher than the ones for EU trade with the world which stand at 43% for exports and 58% for imports. This was the case also before the entry into force of CETA. In turn, this means that the scope for reducing tariffs on products under CETA is limited as no preferences can be provided on goods that are already subject to a 0% duty. NTB reductions can therefore play a more important role, something which will be captured in our regressions with a binary variable as there is no information on what the achievements in CETA means in terms of reducing NTB trade costs in ad-valorem equivalents.

In some of the HS sections where much of EU exports are concentrated - 23% in Machinery (Section XVI) and 22% in Chemicals (Section VI) - duties are primarily at MFN0. In contrast, for Transport equipment, including motor vehicles (Section XVII) which represent 14% of EU

exports to Canada, only 30% of trade is subject to MFN0 duties. The same share applies to Food Products (Section IV) Finally for Agricultural products (Sections I to III taken together), 72% of EU exports are in MFN0 tariff lines.

EU imports in the two main HS sections - Mineral products and Chemical products - takes place at MFN0 rates to values of 96% and 90%, respectively. High shares of imports under MFN0 rates also apply to other HS sections with significant EU imports, in particular Pearls and semi-precious stones (Section XIV) at 97% and Transportation equipment, including motor vehicles at 80%.

Figure 4. EU trade with Canada by tariff regime, 2023



(Source) Eurostat, Global Trade Atlas and MacMap.

C. Use of EU preferences

EU preference eligible imports from Canada amounted to €4.3 billion in 2023 (not displayed)

out of which some €2.5 billion were used, leading to a preference utilization rate (PUR) of close to 60%. Corresponding figures for EU exports stood at €14.2 billion out of which €8.8 billion were used leading to a PUR of 62%. Hence, despite tariff reductions, operators are not making full use of the agreement.

Nilsson (2022) shows that the early months of implementation of CETA has had a strong impact on the PUR. CETA has been applied since late September 2017 and the PUR has increased from about 35% in the first months of application to reach some 60-65%. He further notes heterogeneity among trade partners. For example, the PUR of EU trade with Canada increased less rapidly than for EU trade with Korea in the first years of application of the respective agreement.

Nilsson (2022) also finds that the number of transactions in terms of the same importer-exporter-product combination has a positive impact on the use of preferences PUR and that products that were imported prior to application of CETA are more likely to use preferences once the agreement was applied.

III. Data and Empirical Set-up

A. The data

To analyse the potential impact of CETA on EU trade with Canada, we compare the evolution of trade between the two partners with the evolution of EU trade with all its other trading partners for the period 2013-2023 using annual data.[8] That gives us an 11-year period out of which 5 years are prior to the first full year of application of the agreement (2013-2017) and 6 years are after application (2018-2023).[9]

We conduct the analysis at the lowest level of publicly available trade data, which in the case of EU exports is the 8-digit level of the national classification of importers, while for EU imports we use the 8-digit level of the Combined Nomenclature (CN).[10] Data on EU exports comes from the Global Trade Atlas (GTA) and is mirrored by partner country imports from the EU, according to their national classification. The GTA covers imports of 92 countries from the EU, representing 93% of EU exports. Data on EU imports comes from Eurostat (Comext) and covers all partners.

Duties for EU imports and EU exports (partner country imports from the EU) are taken from Macmap, which also provides estimates of ad-valorem equivalents (AVEs) for specific

8) Our approach is similar to that of Global Affairs (2023).

9) Working with yearly data, CETA's first full calendar year of application was 2018.

10) In the EU, import data exist at a lower level of aggregation but is not made public for confidentiality reasons.

duties, where applicable.[11)]

We control for nomenclature changes and HS revisions, and we exclude all products in the regressions that have been subject to nomenclature changes and/or HS revisions from our sample in all years, as explained in online Annex B. This corresponds 8% of the 4.2 million observations on exports and 9% of the 2.3 million observations on imports.

B. Regression specification

To estimate the impact of CETA on EU trade with Canada, we use the following specification:

$$\ln Y_{ikt} = \alpha + \beta_1 CETA_{it} + \beta_2 AVE_{ikt} + \beta_3 FTA_{it} + \delta_i + \lambda_t + \mu_k + \epsilon_{ikt} \quad (1)$$

where $\ln Y_{ikt}$ is the log value of EU exports to or imports from country i, of product k at time t. One should note that the EU aggregate excludes the UK, and that the UK is not included in the data until 2021 - and then as a partner country - after having left the EU's common commercial policy. Hence, the UK is present in the data for three years during which it has unchanged trade relations (an FTA) with the EU, implying that Brexit does not impact EU-UK bilateral trade in the regressions.

CETA is a dummy taking values of 1 for EU trade with Canada from 2018 and onwards, AVE_{ikt} are the tariffs faced by EU exports to third countries or applied by the EU on imports from third countries and *FTA* is a dummy taking the value of 1 for EU trade in preference eligible products with FTA partners after application of the respective agreements, δ_i controls for time invariant partner country fixed effects, λ_t for time variant shocks common to all countries, like the COVID-19 pandemic, and, to some extent, geopolitical tensions, μ_k are product fixed effects at the CN8 level for EU imports and the HS6 level for EU exports to absorb any product specific time invariant shock,[12)] and ε_{ikt} is the error term.

We augment this specification with additional variables such as the indicator of tariff lines where the MFN rate is zero and various interactions to explore the different level and slope impacts. In addition, we also test a more stringent specification with product-time fixed effects ($\lambda_t * \mu_k$).[13)]

The use of disaggregated data and the introduction of product fixed effects assures that the results are not driven by some non-observed factors. In particular, the quantification of

11) www.macmap.org.

12) While the trade data is in national classifications at the highest level of disaggregation available, the product fixed effects are at HS6 because the national classifications are not homogeneous at 8 digits or higher level of aggregation.

13) Going one step further and introducing country-year fixed effects results in perfect collinearity with the CETA and FTA dummies, which subsequently are dropped from the regressions.

the impact of the agreement (introduced as a dummy variable) is derived from the comparison of the trade between EU and Canada before and after the agreement, for each product, relative to the trade of the EU with all other partners over the same period.

IV. Results

A. EU exports

Table 1 shows the estimation results of the impact of CETA on EU exports. Column 1 shows that EU exports to Canada, after 2018 are on average 37%[14] higher than EU exports before the agreement was applied. Isolating the contribution of the tariff reduction element to the increase in exports (interacting the CETA dummy with the tariffs faced by EU exports) the impact of the agreement becomes 49% as shown in Column 2. This is the combination of the level impact of the CETA dummy and the slope impact of the interaction.[15]

The coefficient of the CETA dummy is robust to controlling for trade in MFN0 lines as shown in Column 3. In addition, EU exports to Canada increased in MFN0 tariff lines after the application of the agreement as shown by the interaction between the CETA dummy and the MFN0 dummy in Column 4. A little less than half of the impact of CETA on EU exports is in MFN0 tariff lines.

The impact on EU exports to other countries with which the EU has FTAs is positive and but not statistically significant (the FTA variable). This result does not necessarily mean that generally EU exports to other FTA countries does not increase after the entry into force of agreements as the variable measuring the tariff reductions already explains the majority of the impact of EU FTAs. Then, with the product fixed effects, there is not enough variation left in the data to precisely estimate the FTA variable. In fact, the identification of the coefficients comes from the variation over time and across importers for each product. Excluding Canada, the FTA variable changes from zero to one, in the period considered (2013-2023), only for 12 countries out of 92 included as destinations of EU exports. Results are robust to the inclusion of product-year fixed effects as shown in Table A2.

14) Derived as (exp(0.318))-1.

15) The average difference in tariffs facing EU exports to Canada between the five years before and the six years after the CETA was applied is a reduction of about 2 percentage points. This difference is multiplied by the value of the interaction variable's coefficient and added to the value of the CETA dummy coefficient. The overall impact of the agreement is then the exponent of this sum minus 1: (exp(0.368+(-0.02)*(-1.622))-1].

Table 1. *Regression Results of the Impact of CETA on EU Exports to Canada*

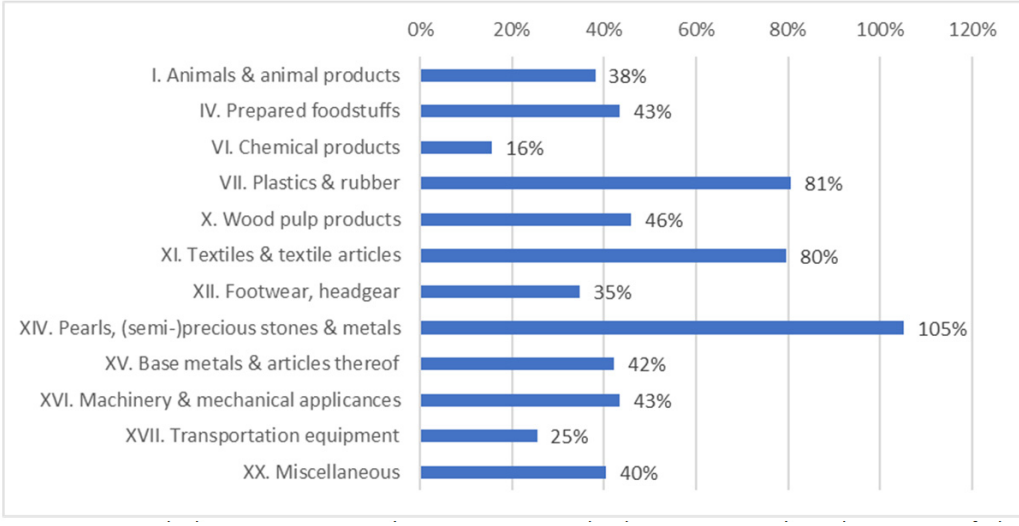
	Log of EU exports			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
CETA	0.318*** [0.021]	0.368*** [0.021]	0.316*** [0.021]	0.210*** [0.031]
AVE	-0.037 [0.025]	-0.035 [0.024]	-0.035 [0.024]	-0.035 [0.024]
CETA*AVE		-1.622*** [0.0932]		
FTA	0.003 [0.008]	0.003 [0.008]	0.003 [0.008]	0.003 [0.008]
MFN0 exp.			0.154*** [0.004]	0.151*** [0.004]
CETA*MFN0 exp.				0.157*** [0.031]
Constant	8.591*** [0.022]	8.591*** [0.022]	8.591*** [0.022]	8.562*** [0.022]
Importer FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
HS6 FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	3,590,906	3,590,906	3,590,906	3,590,906
R-squared	0.46	0.47	0.47	0.47

(Source) Own calculations.
Note. Robust standard errors in brackets *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

1. Results at HS section level

Running the specification of Column 1 for each HS section shows that the impact of the agreement on EU exports is heterogeneous across sections. Overall, there are statistically significant impacts on exports in 12 out of the 21 HS Sections, as shown in Figure 5. Effects are found in HS Sections with a large share of exports at MFN0 rates, such as Wood pulp products (Section X), which has seen exports increase by close to 46% after the application of the agreement. There are effects also in HS sections with a low share of MFN0 exports, e.g., Textiles, the exports of which CETA seems to have increased by 80%. In the three sections where EU exports are mostly concentrated, Machinery, Chemical and Transportation equipment, the agreement has contributed to increase exports by 43%, 16% and 25%, respectively.

Figure 5. CETA impact on EU exports by HS Section (%)



(Source) Own calculations on GTA and Macmap.

Note. the bars correspond to the impact of the statistically significant coefficients (only) of the CETA dummy (exp(β)-1) as reported in Table A4.

B. EU imports

Table 2 shows the regression results according to equation 1 above for EU imports. In the case of imports, the basic specification (Column 1) shows that once CETA was applied, EU imports from Canada have developed slower than EU imports from other partners. As expected, import tariffs in the form of AVEs are negative and statistically significant at the 1% level. Once controlling for the impact of preferential tariffs (included in the AVE variable), EU FTAs have not led to more import from FTA partners compared to imports from non-preferred sources during the 2013-2023 period. Interacting the CETA variable with the AVE variable in column 2 does not change the result. These results are in line with the average trend of total EU imports of goods from Canada relative to imports from the world as shown in Figure 1.

Column 3 adds a dummy variable for EU imports of MFN0 goods, which is positive and statistically significant at the 1% level. The result indicates that EU imports of MFN0 goods, which make out the bulk of EU imports have increased more than EU imports of other types of products. Column 4 interacts the CETA variable with the MFN0 dummy. The coefficient is positive and statistically significant at the 1% level and should be interpreted jointly with the coefficient of the CETA variable. Given that the positive coefficient of the interaction term is larger than the negative coefficient of the CETA dummy, the total impact of CETA is positive. On average EU imports of MFN0 products from Canada have increased 47% more than such imports from other partners. As in the case of exports, the results are robust to the inclusion

of product-year fixed effects as shown in Table A3.

Table 2. *Regression Results of the Impact of CETA on EU Imports from Canada*

	Log of EU imports			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
CETA	-0.136***	-0.135***	-0.162***	-0.535***
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.027)
AVE	-4.819***	-4.819***	-4.785***	-4.863***
	(0.074)	(0.074)	(0.074)	(0.075)
CETA*AVE		-1.329		
		(1.129)		
FTA	-0.052***	-0.052***	-0.059***	-0.061***
	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)
MFN0 imp.			0.578***	0.553***
			(0.012)	(0.012)
CETA*MFN0 imp.				0.919***
				(0.032)
Constant	5.998***	5.998***	5.745***	5.763***
	(0.061)	(0.061)	(0.061)	(0.061)
Exporter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Product (CN8) FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,342,078	2,342,078	2,342,078	2,342,078
Adj. R^2	0.42	0.42	0.42	0.42

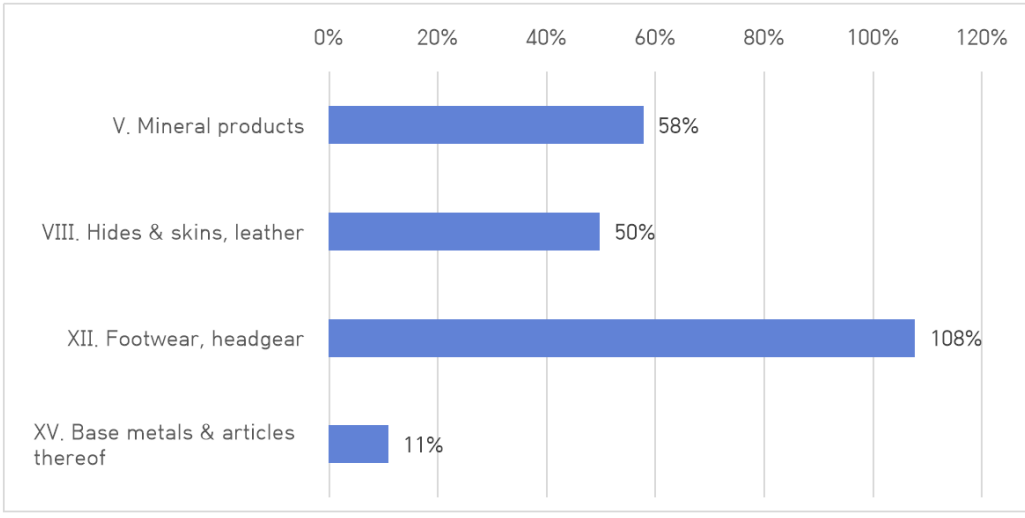
(Source) Own calculations.
Note. Robust standard errors in brackets *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1.

1. Results at HS section level

Next, in Figure 6 we look at the impact of CETA on EU imports at the section level of the HS. Eight out of the 20 HS Sections indicate statistically insignificant results. The coefficients of four sections are positive and statistically significant, while the coefficients for nine sections are negative and statistically significant when we compare to imports of products in the same sectors, but not covered by CETA.

The largest increases in imports are found in Footwear, which has seen imports more than double, followed by Mineral products, and Hides and skins (Section VIII) which have increased by 50-60%. Compared to EU non-CETA imports, EU imports of Vegetable products and Plastics and rubber (Section VII) from Canada are lower at about 50% and 40%, respectively (not displayed). One should note that this does not mean that EU imports from Canada have declined in these HS Sections. It means that EU imports of these product categories have increased more from other partners than from Canada. In fact, EU imports of products of these HS sections are some 35-40% higher for the average 2018-2023 period compared to the 2013-2017 period.

Figure 6. CETA impact on EU imports by HS section (%)



(Source) Own calculations on Comext and Macmap.
Note. the bars correspond to the impact of the statistically significant coefficients of the CETA dummy (exp(β)-1) as reported in Table A5.

V. Summary and Conclusions

EU trade with Canada takes place under MFN0 rates to a greater extent (~80%) than EU trade in general (~50%). In addition, tariffs on products subject to liberalisation under CETA were generally low. This leaves the tariff reduction scope under CETA limited and increases the relative importance of reductions in NTBs that the agreement contains. However, such potential effects are often left out in ex-ante studies as it is difficult to measure the extent to which certain provisions such as enhancing mutual recognition of conformity or the recognition of Geographical Indications actually lower trade costs and how significant these trade cost may be to start with, see Nilsson (2018) for a general such discussion.

The results of our analysis show that CETA has had a positive and statistically significant impact on EU exports to Canada, to the tune of 35%. This result is in line with the findings of Larch and Yotov (2024) on the impact of FTAs on trade. As far as imports are concerned, we find that products liberalised under CETA have experienced lower growth than EU imports from other sources. On the other hand, we find that EU imports of MFN0 goods under CETA have increased faster than EU such imports from other countries. This happens also for exports where about half of the impact of CETA on EU exports is in MFN0 tariff lines. This indicates that EU imports and exports have increased in products where there are no tariff reductions,

which can be due to broader effects of the agreement, including information and awareness effects.[16)]

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